It wasn't only the symbols of rule, turban, robe and sword, that Akbar gave Salim; it wasn't only an official transfer of power that occurred by his bed. Akbar gave Salim more personal tokens of farewell, too: his own rosary and amulets. And then, pulling his long-estranged, lone remaining son into his arms, Akbar gave Salim a final, forgiving kiss.

~

In October 1605, sixty-three years to the month since the light of the world first filled his eyes, the Niru'un died. He might have been pleased by the chronogram for the date of his demise, playing as it does on his name, as Akbar loved to do.

Wafaat-i-Akbar shud.

'Akbar died', it might read; or 'There was a mighty death'. His worst enemies would have agreed, while sighing in relief: both meanings were true.

.The painting is beautifully analysed by the art historian Kavita Singh in Scroll.in (https://scroll.in/article/1000463/as-jahangir-contemplates-a-portrait-of-his-father-a-reversal-of-our-ideas-about-dreams-and-reality).

. Munis D. Faruqui, *The Princes of the Mughal Empire, 1504–1719* (Cambridge University Press, 2012).

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. Ibid.

. Abu'l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 3, trans. Henry Beveridge (First published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

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. Jahangir, *The Jahangirnama: Memoirs of Jahangir, Emperor of India*, ed. and trans. W.M. Thackston (Oxford University Press with the Smithsonian Institution, 1999).

. *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 3.

. Du Jarric, *Akbar and the Jesuits*. At the time of Badauni's writing, it was Akbar's former tutor Abdul Latif's son, Mir Ghiyasuddin Naqib Khan, who was employed in 'reading history, and all books of verse and prose, both day and night' to the emperor.

. Abu'l Fazl, *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1, trans. H. Blochmann (First published 1927; Low Price Publications, 2014).

. Annemarie Schimmel, *The Empire of the Great Mughals: History, Art and Culture* (Reaktion Books, 2004, reprinted in 2010).

. So much so, in fact, that Shah Abbas's court poet Kausari 'regrets that the centre of Persian literature had shifted from Persia to Hindusthan'. See S. Roy, 'Akbar', in *The Mughul Empire*, ed. R.C. Majumdar (Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1974).

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